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PRISONER OF BERLIN

They call it the “Friday news dump”—the practice of releasing bad political news on Friday afternoon to avoid too much attention and media scrutiny. By that time newspaper columns are full of other news and ready to go to print. But the news that reached the White House on the morning of Friday, August 31, which also happened to be the last working day before the Labor Day weekend, could not be concealed or downplayed in that manner. Like a bomb, it would cause devastation no matter when and where dropped. General Marshall S. Carter, the acting director of the CIA, told John Kennedy that the overflight of Cuba by a CIA U-2 spy plane two days earlier had discovered Soviet-made S-75 Desna surface-to-air missiles. They were of the same type that had shot down a U-2 plane over the Soviet Union in May 1960.[1]

CIA analysts looking at the photos taken on August 29 recognized a pattern familiar from other Soviet surface-to-air missile installations: six launchpads connected by makeshift roads, with a command cabin and radar